



So close, yet so far: Angad Bisht (left) had the opportunity to become only the fourth Indian fighter to secure a UFC contract, following Bharat Khandare, Anshul Jubli, and Puja Tomar. But it was not meant to be. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

BISHT BRAVADO IN VAIN

It was yet another **heartbreak for India** at the Ultimate Fighting Championship, as Angad Bisht failed to make the cut after his loss to DongHun Choi.

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The UFC contract was just within arm's reach for Angad Bisht. He needed only two more wins to secure a spot for himself in the promotion.

Bisht had the opportunity to become only the fourth Indian fighter to secure a UFC contract, following Bharat Khandare, Anshul Jubli, and Puja Tomar. But it was not

meant to be.

In the semifinals of the Road to UFC, the Dehradun-based grappler faced DongHun Choi of South Korea, who entered the bout with a spotless record of seven wins out of seven fights. Bisht, on the other hand, had seven in 10.

Choi and Bisht battled back and forth for the full 15 minutes in the

second flyweight matchup, with a spot in the final hanging in the balance.

Bisht started exceptionally well, landing a right hand that caused Choi's nose to bleed instantly.

However, the South Korean wore it well and returned the favour in the second round, executing a perfect knockdown that rattled the Indian fighter in the dying moments of the round.

The match remained highly competitive in the final two rounds, leaving the judges to decide the winner.

When the scores were tallied, Choi emerged the winner by split decision, retaining his perfect record and advancing to the finals in Macau later this year.

Although Bisht's journey ended prematurely, there is still Indian-born Kiru Singh Sahota in contention. He is set to face Choi in the final.

In the opening round, neither Sahota nor his opponent, Ruel Panales, landed any significant blows. However, in the second round, Sahota began to utilise his significant reach advantage, drawing himself away from Panales and threatening with an armbar at the buzzer. In the third round, Sahota continued to land stronger shots, allowing him to pull away from his Filipino opponent.

The judges unanimously favoured Sahota, who improved to 12-2 with the victory and secured his spot in the final.

However, earlier this year at the start of Road to UFC, Sahota was embroiled in controversy. During the ceremonial photoshoot before the main fight card, he refused to hold the Indian flag due to his alleged affiliation with Khalistan.

His actions sparked massive outrage on social media and even prompted UFC India's official Instagram handle to delete the promotional post featuring him.

UFC India posted pictures of all the other Indian fighters but removed Sahota's photo after the controversy.